

PicoCTF 2026 – Bytemancy 2

bytemancy 2

General Skills

Medium

200 pts 2,699 solves

by LT 'syreal' Jones

Can you conjure the right bytes? The program's source code can be downloaded [here](#).

Connect to the program with netcat:

```
$ nc lonely-island.picoctf.net 56615
```

Similar to the other challenges in this series, we want to send the “right bytes” to the script

PicoCTF 2026 – Bytemancy 2

Non-Printable ASCII Bytes

```
print('Send me the HEX BYTE 0xFF 3 times, side-by-side, no space.')  
print()  
print(" ^x^m ^=^p ^x^i ^=^j ^x ^x^h ^=^a ^k ^= ^x^m ^=^p ^x^i ^=  
print(' ^j ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^` ^t^`  
print('==> ', end='', flush=True)  
user_input = sys.stdin.buffer.readline().rstrip(b"\n")  
if user_input == b"\xff\xff\xff":  
    print(open("./flag.txt", "r").read())  
    break
```

If we look at the Python script that runs the app, we see that the app is looking for a specific ASCII byte: 0xFF

PicoCTF 2026 – Bytemancy 2

Non-Printable ASCII Bytes

ASCII Encoding

Decimal	Hexadecimal	ASCII
---------	-------------	-------

255	0xFF	ÿ
-----	------	---

This is made a bit more complicated because the 0xFF byte (ÿ) is not printable on standard (American) keyboards

PicoCTF 2026 – Bytemancy 2

Hex Input for Printf



```
L$ printf "\\xff"
```

Fortunately, if we use the Printf command to send the bytes, it doesn't matter if we can type the actual ASCII character on our keyboards

PicoCTF 2026 – Bytemancy 2

Hex Input for Printf

```
└─$ printf "\xFF\xFF\xFF\x0A" | nc lonely-island.picoctf.net 58646
+-----[ BYTEMANCY-2 ]-----+
0000+DRA0000+DRA0000+DRA000
Send me the HEX BYTE 0xFF 3 times, side-by-side, no space.
0000+DRA0000+DRA0000+DRA000
+-----+
=> picoCTF{3ff5_4_d4px_88a19d45}
```

So we can use Printf to create our ASCII bytes and get the flag